

relatives had gathered to meet her. He introduced her all around. At length he found me, where I stood in a corner doing my very best to look tough.

"And here," said my father, "is your stepson, Napoleon, beyond doubt the meanest boy in Wise County. We don't expect much good from him. I wouldn't be surprised if he starts throwing rocks at you by tomorrow morning."

At that moment, I believe my life hung in the balance.

It was a wise and wonderful woman who placed her hand under my stubborn chin and raised my head so that she could look me squarely in the eyes. She said only a few words, but they lifted me onto an entirely new level.

Turning to my father, my stepmother said: "You are wrong about this boy. He is not the meanest boy in Wise County or anywhere else. He is a very alert and intelligent boy, and all he needs is some worthy objective toward which to direct his very good mind."

That was the first time in my life that anyone had said anything good about me. I straightened up, threw out my chest and grinned. Then and there I sensed that "that woman" who had come to take my mother's place—as my relatives referred to her—was one of those rare people who can help others find the best that is in them.

That was the end of my six-shooter days. Increasingly finding myself as I grew older, I discovered my talent for writing. My stepmother helped me master the typewriter. With the aid of the typewriter I became a writer for newspapers. Through that experience I qualified to interview successful men, and thus I came to sit down with Andrew Carnegie. Out of that interview—which ran on through the better part of three days and nights—came my commitment to search out the secret of successful achievement, not merely as a matter of words, but as a pattern of definite action in the lives of men who have achieved great wealth. Out of this grew the organization of the Science of Personal Achievement which has reverberated around the world, bringing prosperity and peace of mind to millions of men and women.

Great artists also live their own lives, or they could not be great. One of the great opera stars of all time, Madame Schumann-Heink, as a young girl went to a music teacher to have her voice tested. He listened a few minutes, then said brusquely: "That's enough! Go back to your sewing machine. You may become a first-class seamstress. A singer, no!"